



ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION
UNION PANAFRICAINE DES ETUDIANTS
الاتحاد جميع الطلاب الأفريقي
Defending students rights since 1972



African Girls Back To School Campaign Project



2021

PROJECT SUMMARY

The “Girls Back to School Campaign”, is a gender flagship project of the UNESCO Global Education Coalition (GEC). The All-Africa Students Union joined the UNESCO GEC in 2020, with the sole aim of ensuring that education continues during and post COVID-19.

The Global Education Coalition launched by UNESCO, is a platform for collaboration and exchange to protect the right to education during this unprecedented disruption and beyond. It brings together more than 140 members from the UN family, civil society, academia and the private sector to ensure that Learning Never Stops.

Since the launch of the coalition’s gender flagship project, the All-Africa Students Union, as a coalition member, has been working with the 100 Million Campaign (a global coalition that ensures that girls are free, safe and educated) to engage over 60 youth activists to demand an education for every girl during and post COVID-19. This campaign is to ensure the right of every girl to quality education is guaranteed. Around the world, 130 million were out of school before COVID-19 and the pandemic threatens to halt the education of more than 11 million girls.

So far, the campaign has engaged volunteers from twenty-nine(29) African countries.

These countries include:

- Burundi
- Cameroon
- Democratic Republic of Congo
- Congo Brazzaville
- Egypt
- Ethiopia
- Ghana
- Gabon
- Gambia
- Guinea
- Guinea Bissau

PROJECT SUMMARY

- Eswatini
- Ivory Coast
- Kenya
- Lesotho
- Liberia
- Malawi
- Mauritius
- Morocco
- Namibia
- Nigeria
- Rwanda
- Sierra Leone
- Sao Tome
- South Africa
- Sudan
- Zimbabwe
- Uganda
- Gambia
- Zambia

The campaign commenced in September, 2020 with a launch by the Global Coalition. The Union picked this up with an African launch and placed a call for campaign coordinators in all the 54 African countries. Once the coordinators had been duly confirmed, it was followed by a 2-day intensive training facilitated by the 100 million campaign for all country coordinators using resources like the youth advocacy toolkit and the community radio toolkit developed by UNESCO. The All-Africa Students Union has been duly recognised in the UNESCO GEC Gender Flagship Report as being one of the organisations that has employed the youth advocacy toolkit.

NEEDS OR PROBLEMS THE PROJECT SEEKS TO SOLVE

The economic impacts of COVID-19 have been widespread and devastating, particularly for women and girls. The crisis has caused great economic hardship, which puts families under pressure. The big question of whether families in deprived areas in Africa can afford to send their daughters back to school in this season and post COVID-19 remains. At the peak of the COVID-19 pandemic, more than 1.5 million learners were affected by school closures in 200 countries. More than 760 million of them were girls. When girls are not in school, they are often called on to help more with domestic tasks. In some settings, they are more likely to be married at a young age or become pregnant when they are still children themselves. These are barriers to their return to education. While many girls will continue with their education once schools reopen, some may never return to school. In every country and community in Africa, we must prioritize the needs of girls in education or risk losing the progress achieved over the past 20 years. National public health guidance and the need for a safe return to school cannot be overemphasized. In other countries, concerns for public health and safety have kept schools closed longer which requires we help girls to continue learning by other means.

CAMPAIGN DEMANDS

Young African activists are asking African governments to act in a manner that will ensure that the education of young girls is not cut short. Some of these demands include the following:

- Ensuring sufficient emergency healthcare services;
- Providing logistical educational support;
- Proposing scholarships for girls where applicable;
- Guaranteeing reliable supply of food and potable water;
- Ensuring schools are equipped with adequate WASH (Water, Sanitation and Healthcare Waste Management systems) facilities; and
- Where necessary, assist with financial support to families with low or no income.

OVERVIEW OF CAMPAIGN PROGRESS MADE

The intervention of volunteers has taken many forms such as community sensitization, engagement with people in authority, and media coverage including social media. The campaign has focused on grassroots to key stakeholders to ensure that work gets done. There have been online engagements (Twitter, Facebook) to shed light on the existing hiccups in the education sector and the effects on girls' education. The Twitter charts, key messages designed on girls' education have raised awareness, amplified the voices of girls and has since seen different people/ stakeholders join the campaign and speak up on girls' education and demand action from duty bearers.

The girls back to school campaign has been very productive in **Kenya** and has seen great success. Some successes chalked include the government of Kenya adopting some of the recommendations the volunteers of the project in Kenya gave to support girls' education. Among these are the provision of sanitary towels to all adolescent girls in schools for free through their ministry of education which supports girls to stay in school by way of reducing absenteeism of girls during their menstruation periods. Kenya convened its first sensitization meeting with 800 girls from different schools in Busia, Kenya. Religious leaders, chiefs and youth leaders from the area were not left out. The campaign was extended to Central Kenya, Muranga county where they engaged 50 mothers and 200 girls from different schools and were joined by the country government representatives which made a great impact. In Nairobi, the campaign started in slum areas. Volunteers in Kenya were not able to provide direct mentorship to school girls due to limited resources but were able to strike a partnership deal to work with Sub County Ministry of Health officers through their school health program to intervene in providing medical services to school-going

OVERVIEW OF CAMPAIGN PROGRESS MADE

children and cover pregnant school girls while helping them overcome the stigma that comes with teenage pregnancy. The partnership would further strengthen their school health program but they are financially limited to do much.

In **Nigeria**, young Leaders have been selected from each state summing it up to 36 states.

The focus in Nigeria is to reach out to girls in the rural areas who are not in school due to poverty and hence their parents cannot afford them school uniforms, educational materials, food and some due to pregnancy. Also, **Guinea Conakry** which is a francophone country recently launched the campaign in their country in the cities of Conakry and N'zérékoré, and are mobilizing people to embark on this campaign.

The campaign has been running in Uganda in the district of Kamuli where partnerships have been built with districts to further girls' education and fight child marriages which have been a big hindrance to girls' education in the district. They are working with different stakeholders; police, religious, local and cultural leaders in the communities to end Child marriages and ensure girls are not only safe in the communities but are returning to school. The involvement of parents and the girls themselves has been a great step for the campaign in Uganda. Girls have been able to share their experiences and use their voices to speak up on the inequalities in the educational system and demand improved service delivery. 30 girls have written letters to their leaders whereas others have been recorded and their Voices amplified online and videos shared with the respective leaders. In response to this, the speaker of parliament provided over 6000 sanitary pads to girls in Kamuli district after the volunteers shared stories of girls online whose education has been affected in Kamuli district due to lack of sanitary pads.

OVERVIEW OF CAMPAIGN PROGRESS MADE

The campaign has further been extended to Isingiro district and Nakivaale Refugee Settlement where they are working with Best Future School to ensure girls in the refugee settlement and those with albinism access education. Male support groups have also been set up to champion the fight against child marriages in that community. There has been participation in press conferences on the retention of girls that are pregnant in school which shortly after saw the government of Uganda allow pregnant girls to return to school and allow them to register and sit for their final exam. It is worthy to note that follow-ups have been made on some of these pregnant girls and how they are coping.

Uganda is currently working on putting together girls' voices in a documentary that shall be used for advocacy purposes. They are also following up on the speaker on concrete solutions to support girls' education in the district like providing scholarships, logistical support and building changing rooms for girls for some of the schools that need them like Balawoli Primary School.

Burundi has also had meetings with school authorities including university rectors where they agreed to implement the campaign's objectives into their operations.

PROJECT END- BENEFICIARIES

The campaign is expected to ensure the safe return of all girls of school-going age to school without any discrimination of any sort, especially for girls who have subjected to social injustice. The following includes some of the targeted beneficiaries as per the objects of this campaign:

(1) Less privileged girls

Less privileged girls in this context is defined to mean those girls whose families may not have the financial capacity to pay huge sums as school fees or afford the needed learning materials. No girl should be denied an education because they couldn't afford especially under the current economic hardships the pandemic has meted out on so many families. We will be asking governments and other organisations to make budgetary allocations for such persons. Where possible, deadlines for fees payment should be extended to give ample time for girl students to study and pay their fees at an appropriate time

(2) Pregnant girls.

(3) Abused girls.

(4) Girls involved in child labour.

KEY ACTIVITIES TO BE IMPLEMENTED

- (1) Call for coordinators
- (2) Training for coordinators
- (3) Written letters to key decision makers
- (4) In-country webinars/dialogues
- (5) Distribution of sanitary pads to less privileged girls.
- (6) Establishing clubs in schools and peer groups in communities to ensure the sustainability of the campaign.

Sustainability Plans

SUSTAINABILITY PLANS

- (1) Establishment of clubs and peer groups in schools and communities to champion the course of the campaign even after the duration of the campaign.
- (2) Train volunteers to become expert advocates in girl child education.
- (3) Ensure quarterly monitoring sessions on achieved goals and constant follow up on benefic

EXPECTED OUTCOMES

- (1)** Safe return of all girls to school and to learning during this COVID-19 crisis and post covid.
- (2)** Pregnant girls are not excluded from furthering their education.
- (3)** That girls can continue learning in other ways, even if schools stay closed, and have full access to other ways of learning
- (4)** Increased awareness on the general benefit of girl-education for communities and countries
- (5)** Sensitization of communities on the negative consequences for girls and communities when girls are unable to receive education

Partners

- (1)** UNESCO



- (2)** 100 Million campaign



PARTNERS